

LEVERAGING EVIDENCE FOR EFFECTIVE ANTICIPATORY ACTION

KEY NOTE SPEAKERS



Karen Macours

J-PAL Affiliated Researcher; Chaired Professor at the Paris School of Economics (PSE); Directrice de Recherche INRAE; Editor-in-Chief of the Journal of Development Economics



Dean Karlan

Professor of Economics and Finance at Northwestern University; Founder of Innovations for Poverty Action (IPA)

 **20-21 APRIL 2026**



FAO Headquarters in Rome:
Austria room & online

Anticipatory action (AA) enables humanitarian actors to act before crises escalate by linking forecasts and early warning systems with pre-arranged financing and early interventions that protect lives, livelihoods, and food security. Evidence from multiple countries has demonstrated the effectiveness of AA, while also highlighting the challenges of evaluating its impact in fragile and crisis-affected contexts. As AA expands and resources remain constrained, there is increasing demand for **rigorous evidence** on effectiveness, efficiency, prediction accuracy, and cost-effectiveness to inform program design, guide donor investments, and scale approaches where they work best. This workshop brings together practitioners, researchers, evaluators, Members, and partners **to strengthen anticipatory action through improved analytics, learning, and collaboration, and to explore innovations in technology and disaster risk financing that can help translate evidence into action at scale.**

Objectives

- **Review emerging evidence and lessons** from the field to strengthen anticipatory action across contexts.
- Advance **rigorous methods and analytical approaches** for evaluating AA in fragile and crisis-affected settings.
- **Support evidence-based decisions** on scaling and financing AA, focusing on effectiveness, efficiency, and return on investment.
- **Explore innovations in technology** and disaster risk financing that enable early warning, better targeting, and timely resources.
- **Identify collaboration opportunities** across academia, international organizations, donors, and civil society.
- **Align evidence needs with funding priorities** to accelerate adoption and scale of anticipatory action.

REGISTER NOW!

*In-person attendance is not guaranteed due to limited places



09:00–09:30 Welcome coffee & registration

Opening remarks: The evidence imperative in anticipatory action

- 09:30–09:55
- **Speakers:** David Laborde (FAO), Rein Paulsen (FAO), Inger Bordal (Norad), Sarah Klassen (FCDO), Annette Schneegans (EU)

Setting the stage: Objectives and approach

- 09:55–10:15
- **Speakers:** Antonio Scognamiglio (FAO), Niccolò Lombardi (FAO)

Evaluating what matters: evidence standards in crisis contexts

- 10:15–11:15
- **Keynote speaker:** Karen Macours (J-PAL)
 - The keynote will examine the role of rigorous impact evaluation in humanitarian settings, including methods for assessing anticipatory interventions while balancing analytical rigor with operational realities.

11:15–11:30 Coffee break

Evidence in action: impact evaluation case studies

- 11:30–13:00
- **Speakers:** Kamran Khan Niazi (FAO), Ghassan Baliki (ISDC), Clemens Gros (Climate Centre), Ashley Pople (WB), Jennifer Waidler (WFP), Tefera Delbiso (FAOET)
 - A series of fast-paced presentations will spotlight the latest Anticipatory Action evaluations from diverse contexts: drought, floods, polycrisis etc.

13:00–14:00 Lunch break

Turning analytics into timely action: decision support for anticipatory action

- 14:00–15:30
- **Speakers:** Alberto Cabezas (Oxford), Raisa Spencer (FAOSLC), Luca Rossi (UNDRR), Livia Peiser (NSL), Paul Christian (WB), Neil Marsland (FAO), Duccio Piovani (WFP), Simon Polichinel (PRIO)
 - This session will focus on decision support systems that can help translate risk information into timely and well-targeted anticipatory action.

15:30–15:45 Coffee break

Breaking down silos: coordination, data sharing, and joint evaluations

- 15:45–17:15
- **Speakers:** Hanna Paulose (OCHA), Romina Cavatassi (WB), Sara Burrone (FAO), Sara Merner (J-PAL), Clemens Gros (Climate Centre), Jesse Mason (WFP)
 - This session will shift the conversation from the “why” to the “how” of collaboration on AA analytics and evaluations.

17:15 Networking aperitivo at FAO rooftop



09:00–09:15 Welcome coffee

Opening remarks: From evidence to action

- 09:15–09:30
- **Speakers:** Clemencia Cosentino (FAO)

Anticipatory action for agriculture and food security: voices from the field

- 09:30–11:00
- **Speakers:** Rodrigue Vinet (FAO), Aneel Memon (FAOSO), Sylvie Montebault (FAOAF), Matthias Amling (WHH), Melanie Ogle (IFRC), Emma Cazou (START Network), Alex Humphrey (Mercy Corps), Franciscar Rionokou Ekal (WFP)

11:00–11:15 Coffee break

Members perspectives and evidence use: What do we still need?

- 11:15–12:45
- **Speakers:** Katrin Planta (GFFO), Inger Brodal (NORAD), Sarah Klassen (FCDO), Lieven De La Marche (Belgium Ambassador to Rome-based Agencies), Annette Schneegans (EU) and Perla Gines (Government of the Philippines)
 - This session will explore the evidence governments, Members, and partners need to justify scaling investments in anticipatory action.

12:45–13:45 Lunch break

Financing foresight: scaling anticipatory action through risk financing

- 13:45–14:45
- **Speakers:** Daniel Pfister (OCHA), Matthew Keil (FAO), Emilia Wahlstrom (UNDRR), Mathieu Dubreuil (WFP), Yasaman Matinroshan (FAO), Adam McVie (CDP)
 - We will explore how disaster risk financing (DRF) can secure the timely, predictable, and pre-positioned resources needed to deliver anticipatory action at scale.

Aligning evidence and action: Reflections from a donor, implementer, and researcher

- 14:45–15:45
- **Keynote speaker:** Dean Karlan
 - **Other speakers:** Clemencia Cosentino (OED Director)
 - This session will unpack how rigorous research translates (or fails to translate) into policy and programming decisions.

15:45–16:00 Coffee break

What's next? Interactive session on progress gaps and way forward for anticipatory action

- 16:00–17:00
- **Speakers:** Antonio Scognamiglio (FAO), Niccolò Lombardi (FAO)
 - Synthesizing the key takeaways from the two-day dialogue, identifying the most critical evidence gaps and unanswered research questions, and co-creating a roadmap for strengthening AA evaluation over the next 2-3 years.

Closing remarks and way forward

- 17:00–17:30
- **Speakers:** Máximo Torero (FAO Chief Economist), David Laborde (FAO) and Maxwell Sibhensana (FAO)